

THE HILL

Episode 1 — “Mulberry Township”

Pilot Script Draft — Act Four

Version 0.1 Continued

ACT FOUR — “THE CHICKEN DINNER”

EXT. HORNER HOMESTEAD — LATE AFTERNOON

The light is gold but thin.

A chicken flaps across the yard, chased by Christopher.

John Samuel follows, not laughing — making sure Christopher does not cross the invisible line where the yard becomes danger.

Mary Ann stands at the doorway, watching them with a tightness she cannot shake.

Permelia plucks another chicken near the wash area.

Her hands are steady.

Her face is not.

William returns from the tree line.

WILLIAM
They're close.

Permelia does not look up.

PERMELIA
How close.

WILLIAM
Close enough I don't like the quiet.

Mary Ann hears that.

She looks toward the ridge.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — LATE AFTERNOON

The table is being set.

Not a feast.

Not a celebration.

Just a meal.

Bread.

Chicken.

Beans.

A little molasses.

The kind of meal that should feel comforting.

It does not.

Spencer enters, wiping his hands.

SPENCER

We eat before dark.

William glances at him.

WILLIAM

We should eat after.

SPENCER

We eat when we eat.

Permelia sets down a plate harder than she means to.

PERMELIA

We eat now.

That ends the argument.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD — SAME

Jess Wilson and the second rider stand in the trees.

Jess looks down at the homestead.

The second rider adjusts his reins.

SECOND RIDER

You sure?

Jess does not answer.

He watches the house.

He watches the table being set.

He watches the children.

He watches the light.

Then:

JESS

Not yet.

They back their horses into the timber.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — EVENING

The family sits.

Christopher between Mary Ann and Permelia.

John Samuel beside William.

Spencer at the head.

The food is passed quietly.

No one speaks at first.

Then Christopher breaks the silence.

CHRISTOPHER
Can I have more?

Mary Ann gives him a small piece.

Spencer watches the boy eat.

SPENCER
Slow down.

Christopher slows.

John Samuel does not eat much.

He keeps looking at the door.

William notices.

WILLIAM
Eat.

JOHN SAMUEL
I ain't hungry.

WILLIAM
You will be.

John Samuel takes a bite.

Mary Ann watches him.

She knows he is listening for something.

EXT. HORNER HOMESTEAD — SAME

The ridge is darker now.

The road is empty.

But the emptiness feels intentional.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — CONTINUOUS

Permelia lifts her cup.

Her hand shakes once.

She steadies it.

SPENCER
You alright.

PERMELIA
I'm tired of listening.

Spencer nods.

He understands.

He is tired too.

But he will not say it.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD — SAME

Jess Wilson sits on his horse.

He looks down at the house.

The second rider leans forward.

SECOND RIDER
They're all there.

Jess nods.

JESS
They usually are.

SECOND RIDER
We could—

Jess cuts him off with a look.

JESS
Not tonight.

The second rider frowns.

JESS (CONT'D)

They're watching the road.

He turns his horse.

They disappear into the trees.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — EVENING

The family finishes eating.

Mary Ann gathers plates.

Christopher yawns.

John Samuel stands and goes to the doorway.

He looks out.

The yard is still.

The ridge is dark.

He steps back inside.

JOHN SAMUEL

They ain't coming tonight.

Everyone freezes.

William looks at him sharply.

WILLIAM

Why you say that.

JOHN SAMUEL

Because it's too quiet.

Spencer stands.

SPENCER

Bed.

JOHN SAMUEL

I ain't tired.

SPENCER

Bed.

John Samuel obeys.

But he looks back at the adults.

He knows something they will not say.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — NIGHT

The house settles.

The table is cleared.

The fire burns low.

Mary Ann tucks Christopher in.

Permelia checks the latch again.

William sits near the door.

Spencer sits with his rifle across his knees.

John Samuel lies awake, eyes open.

He listens.

He hears:

the creek.

the wind.

a distant horse.

maybe two.

He does not move.

He just listens.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD — NIGHT

Jess Wilson and the second rider sit in the dark.

Watching.

Waiting.

SECOND RIDER

Tomorrow.

Jess does not answer.

He watches the house.

The light inside.

The silhouettes.

The family.

JESS

Tomorrow.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — NIGHT

John Samuel's eyes stay open.

He hears the faintest sound.

A horse.

Then another.

He whispers to himself:

JOHN SAMUEL

Tomorrow.

CUT TO BLACK.

END OF ACT FOUR.